

Title: Maritime Trade Networks in the Early Modern Indian Ocean

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Abstract

The Indian Ocean trade system of the sixteenth and seventeenth centuries connected East Africa, the Arabian Peninsula, South Asia, and Southeast Asia through a dense web of maritime routes. This paper draws on customs records from Gujarati and Omani port cities to reconstruct patterns of commodity flow and merchant networks prior to and during early European intervention.

1. Introduction

Existing accounts of Indian Ocean trade have often centered European trading companies as the primary organizing force. This study instead foregrounds indigenous merchant networks, arguing that established Gujarati, Omani, and Malay trading houses retained substantial commercial autonomy well into the seventeenth century.

2. Sources

Port customs registers from Surat, Muscat, and Malacca provide detailed records of vessel arrivals, cargo manifests, and duty payments. These records, cross-referenced with merchant correspondence, allow reconstruction of trade volumes and network structure.

3. Findings

Textiles, spices, and precious metals dominated cargo manifests, with Gujarati merchant houses controlling an estimated 60 percent of textile exports from Surat throughout the period studied. European trading companies captured a growing share of the spice trade but had minimal presence in textile commerce until the later seventeenth century.

4. Conclusion

Indigenous merchant networks demonstrated considerable resilience and adaptive capacity in the face of European commercial expansion, maintaining dominant positions in specific commodity sectors for decades after initial European contact.